All figures sourced from Government of Canada and Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal and provincial statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

Section 2.6 — The Lifecycle Reassessment Thread

Movement One walked the cascade for the working-age person whose body fails. Movement Two has so far walked the federal program architecture and the Alberta provincial layer that operates at the senior stage. This Section pulls those two perspectives together into a single observation about the system's design: that it operates by continuous reassessment, that each reassessment is an opportunity for benefit reduction, and that the reassessment thread runs from infancy to long-term care without a single point at which a permanent finding of disability or need produces durable, non-revisable support.

Birth and infancy

A child born with a disability in Alberta enters the public system through the medical-records architecture of Alberta Health Services, the early-intervention system administered through Family Support for Children with Disabilities (FSCD), and the Alberta School Act provisions for accommodation in education. (*Source: Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act, R.S.A. 2003; Government of Alberta — FSCD program page, 2026.*) FSCD provides funding for specialized services, respite care, equipment, and other supports for families raising children with disabilities. The program is income-tested for some service categories and not income-tested for others. Eligibility is determined at the application stage and reviewed periodically thereafter.

The reassessment pattern begins early. FSCD funding levels for an individual child are reviewed annually or at specific transition points (entering school, advancing through school grades, aging into specialized programs). Each review can adjust the funding level, the service categories provided, and the service provider relationships. Each review is an opportunity for the parent advocating for the child to defend the existing supports against potential reduction, to provide updated medical and educational documentation, and to navigate the bureaucratic process that determines what the child receives. Inclusion Alberta's January 2025 report documented that the FSCD reassessment process produces meaningful uncertainty for families and that reduction in funding levels following reassessment is a documented experience for many families. (*Source: Inclusion Alberta — "Experiences with Family Support for Children with Disabilities," January 2025.*)

School age

A child with a disability entering the Alberta school system is subject to assessment under the provincial special-education funding formula. Alberta Education's funding to school authorities for students with mild, moderate, and severe disabilities is allocated through grants tied to coded disability categories. Each student's coding is reviewed periodically. A student whose disability profile changes — which it may do as a function of normal child development, as a function of treatment effectiveness or ineffectiveness, or as a function of changing diagnostic standards — may be recoded. Recoding can increase or decrease the funding the school authority receives for the student's supports.

The school authority decides how to deploy the funding. The student's actual support arrangement — educational assistant time, specialist services, classroom accommodations, individual education plan provisions — is determined by the school administration on the basis of the funding available and the school's other operational priorities. The parent advocates for the student's specific needs within whatever envelope the funding produces.

This is not, in any structural sense, a permanent or guaranteed support. Each year is a fresh allocation. Each transition between grade levels is a fresh review. The student whose support was adequate in grade three may have inadequate support in grade four, not because the student's needs have changed but because the school authority's allocation has changed or the school's deployment of resources has shifted.

Age 18 and the FSCD-to-AISH/PDD transition

At age eighteen, FSCD funding ends. A young adult with a disability entering adulthood is subject to fresh determination under either Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) or AISH, depending on the nature and severity of the disability. (*Source: Persons with Developmental Disabilities Services Act, RSA 2007, c P-7.5; AISH Act, R.S.A. 2000, c. A-45.1; Inclusion Alberta — PDD Current State: Critical and Urgent, January 2025.*) The transition is not automatic. The young adult must apply. The young adult's parent or guardian, in most cases, manages the application. The application requires fresh medical documentation, fresh financial documentation, and fresh adjudication.

PDD eligibility is determined by demonstration of a developmental disability with onset before age eighteen and significant adaptive-functioning impairment. AISH eligibility is determined by the medical and financial criteria documented in Section 1.3. A young adult may qualify for one but not the other, for both, or for neither. The reassessment at age eighteen is the most consequential reassessment in the lifecycle for many disabled Albertans, because the supports that have been in place since infancy or childhood may not carry forward at the same level — or at all — into the adult system.

For the young adult who qualifies for AISH, the working-age architecture documented in Movement One begins. The asset cap. The cohabitation rule. The medical evidence requirement on each application and reassessment. The post-July-2026 transition to ADAP. The Medical Review Panel that has replaced the independent Citizens Appeal Panel. Each of these is now part of the young adult's life, on top of the disability they have lived with since infancy.

Working age

Sections 1.1 through 1.4 documented the working-age stage in operational detail. The reassessment pattern continues. AISH recipients are subject to reassessment of medical eligibility and financial eligibility on a periodic basis, with the specific frequency varying by disability category and recipient circumstance. Each reassessment requires updated medical documentation, updated financial disclosure, and adjudication that may produce continuation, modification, or termination of benefits. The post-July-2026 ADAP framework adds the personalized employment action plan requirement, which functions as an ongoing reassessment of employment readiness.

For the worker whose disability emerges in adulthood — the cascade traced from Section 1.1 — the reassessment pattern begins at the moment of WCB application and continues through Maximum Medical Improvement adjudication, deeming reassessment, IME-driven adjustment, AISH application, AISH reassessment, AISH-to-ADAP transition, and ADAP ongoing review. Each reassessment is documented. Each reassessment is, in operational reality, an opportunity for benefit reduction.

The 60-to-64 gap zone

The 60-to-64 age band is the single most structurally exposed part of the senior-system lifecycle. (*Source: Statistics Canada — Income of Senior Women, 2017 and 2022; National Institute on Ageing — Pre-Senior*

Income Insecurity in Canada, 2023.) The Alberta worker in this age band is too young for OAS (eligibility begins at sixty-five), too young for GIS (eligibility begins at sixty-five), and too young for the Alberta Seniors Benefit (eligibility begins at sixty-five). They are at or past the upper edge of WCB Economic Loss Payment eligibility for many injury types (Section 1.2 documented the age-65 cliff and the policy's treatment of normal retirement age as 65 or 5 years after date of accident, whichever is later). They may have been on AISH and remained eligible until age sixty-five (AISH terminates at age sixty-five), but the AISH-to-ADAP transition documented in Section 1.4 has changed the operational reality of late-AISH receipt for many Albertans.

The federal Allowance program documented in Section 2.4 is available only to spouses or common-law partners of OAS recipients. A single 60-to-64 individual with no current OAS-receiving spouse is not eligible for the Allowance. The Allowance for the Survivor is available only to individuals who have been widowed and have not remarried or entered a new common-law relationship. A 60-to-64 individual who is divorced, never-married, or in a relationship with a partner under sixty-five is not eligible for the Allowance for the Survivor.

The 60-to-64 individual without a current spouse who has aged out of WCB, whose AISH eligibility has terminated, who has not yet reached OAS eligibility, and who does not qualify for the Allowance or Allowance for the Survivor has, in current operational reality, the following income options: provincial Income Support (the general welfare program in Alberta, at substantially lower benefit levels than AISH), early CPP retirement (available from age sixty at a permanently reduced rate, approximately thirty-six per cent below the age-65 amount), private retirement savings if any exist, and family support if available. There is no senior-system income support for this individual until age sixty-five.

The structural exclusion of the 60-to-64 single individual is documented across Canadian senior-poverty literature as a contributor to the higher poverty rates among single seniors (particularly women) than among coupled seniors. (*Source: Statistics Canada — Income of Senior Women, 2017 and 2022; National Institute on Ageing — Pre-Senior Income Insecurity, 2023.*) The exclusion is not the result of an oversight in program design. The exclusion is the result of program-design choices that prioritized supporting senior couples (where one partner has reached OAS eligibility) and prioritized supporting widowed survivors over supporting individuals who are unattached for any other reason. The choice has been documented and critiqued for decades. The choice has not been changed.

Age 65 and the federal-provincial transition

At age sixty-five, multiple transitions occur simultaneously, as documented in Section 1.6. AISH or ADAP eligibility ends. OAS eligibility begins. CPP-D converts to CPP retirement. WCB Economic Loss Payments are recalculated under the age-65 cliff formula. GIS eligibility begins, subject to income testing. Alberta Seniors Benefit eligibility begins, subject to OAS-receipt and income-threshold tests. Coverage for Seniors begins. Dental and Optical Assistance for Seniors begins. The senior-system architecture documented across Movement Two engages.

Each of these transitions is an application, a determination, an adjudication, or a recalculation. The recipient does not automatically receive the senior-system benefits at age sixty-five; they receive them after applying, providing documentation, and being approved. The applications are not coordinated. There is no single transition office, no single transition application, and no single point of accountability if the transitions do not align.

For a senior with multiple medical needs, limited literacy or cognitive capacity, or limited social supports, the age-sixty-five transition is administratively challenging in ways that produce documented benefit gaps. The senior who does not complete one of the applications on time experiences an income gap in the months around their sixty-fifth birthday. The senior who applies for OAS but not GIS does not receive GIS until they apply for it separately. The senior who is deferring OAS at sixty-five, whether by intent or by missed application, is ineligible for any of the Alberta provincial seniors programs during the deferral period.

The age-sixty-five transition is the most significant administrative event in many senior lifecycles. It is also one of the least well-supported. The elimination of individual AISH caseworkers in 2024-25 and the replacement of those caseworkers with a centralized call centre extend the operational reality of poorly supported transitions to recipients aging out of AISH.

Age 75 and the OAS differential

At age seventy-five, the OAS amount increases by ten per cent. The 75-and-over rate documented in Section 2.1 produces an additional eighty to ninety dollars per month in OAS income relative to the 65-to-74 rate. This is the only senior-system reassessment that produces an increase rather than a decrease. The increase was implemented in July 2022 under federal legislation and is, in current operational reality, the most significant pro-senior structural change in the senior income system in the past decade. Its durability is contingent on the political durability of the differentiation, which the Section 2.1 documentation of OAS political vulnerability identifies as not assured.

Long-term care entry

At the point at which a senior can no longer manage at home — typically in the late seventies, eighties, or nineties, but sometimes earlier — the senior enters long-term care. The entry is preceded by a comprehensive assessment of the senior's care needs and financial circumstances. (*Source: Government of Alberta — Continuing Care Assessment process, 2026.*) The assessment determines the level of care required, the appropriate accommodation type, the accommodation charge, and the eligibility for income supports to offset the accommodation charge.

The financial assessment is the senior's last reassessment. It determines what portion of the senior's income is consumed by the accommodation charge, what portion is preserved for the senior's disposable use (the disposable-income guarantee documented in Section 2.5), and what portion of the senior's assets must be drawn down to cover costs that exceed the income coverage. For the senior with substantial assets, the long-term care years can deplete those assets at a rate of forty to seventy thousand dollars per year (less the income coverage). For the senior with no significant assets, the income coverage and the disposable-income guarantee are the operational reality of their financial life until death.

The long-term care assessment is also the last opportunity for the senior to be reassessed for benefit eligibility. The Alberta Seniors Benefit nursing-home rate, documented in Section 2.5 ($12,312 annually for a single senior in a nursing home, $16,104 for a couple where one partner is in a nursing home), engages at this point. The senior whose income falls within the threshold qualifies. The senior whose income exceeds the threshold does not. The threshold is not adjusted for the cost of long-term care.

Death and the survivor's reassessment

When a senior dies, their OAS, CPP retirement, and other federal benefits end. The surviving spouse is subject to a fresh reassessment. The surviving spouse's GIS is recalculated against the new (single-rate) income test. The surviving spouse's Alberta Seniors Benefit is recalculated. The surviving spouse may qualify for a CPP Survivor Benefit, calculated against a separate formula, at typically sixty per cent of the deceased spouse's CPP retirement amount (with adjustments). The surviving spouse may qualify for the Allowance for the Survivor if widowed at age 60-64.

The surviving spouse's income, in most cases, drops by more than half at the death of the partner. Two OAS pensions become one. Two CPP retirement pensions become one (plus the Survivor Benefit, which is typically less than the deceased spouse's full pension). The single-recipient GIS rate is higher than the couple-recipient rate per person, but it is lower than the combined couple amount. The household's monthly income drops sharply at the same time that the household's expenses (housing, utilities, transportation, food) do not drop proportionally. The surviving spouse's poverty risk increases. The risk is documented across Canadian senior-women's-poverty literature as a primary driver of senior-women's-poverty rates. (*Source: Statistics Canada — Income of Senior Women in Canada, multiple reference periods; Public Health Agency of Canada — Health Inequalities in Canada, women and aging report, 2023.*)

What the lifecycle thread shows

The lifecycle reassessment thread runs from infancy to widowhood without a single point at which a permanent finding produces permanent support. Each transition is a reassessment. Each reassessment is an opportunity for the system to reduce what the recipient receives. The reassessments are not coordinated across programs. The recipient navigates each one separately. The cumulative impact of forty to ninety years of reassessment is the income trajectory documented across Movement One and Movement Two of this document.

The system is not designed to ensure stable support. The system is designed to make periodic determinations of eligibility against criteria that may change between determinations. The system is designed to require the recipient to demonstrate continued eligibility on each reassessment. The system is designed to allow benefit reduction at any reassessment if the criteria, the recipient's documentation, the political environment, or the budget context permits.

This is the cage in its most fully developed form. It is not a single rule. It is the architecture of continuous reassessment.

Section 2.7 walks the partnership penalty mechanism stage by stage, with the published math, demonstrating how this single mechanism operates across the lifecycle in different programs at different rates with the same structural effect.